

**ESTONIA****Capital city:** Tallinn**Area:** 17,462 sq miles (45,226 sq km)**Population:** 1,300,000**Official language:** Estonian**Major religions:** Christian 81%, other 19%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** Kroon**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 71 years**People per doctor:** 323**Televisions:** 480 per 1,000 people**LATVIA****Capital city:** Riga**Area:** 24,938 sq miles (64,589 sq km)**Population:** 2,300,000**Official language:** Latvian**Major religions:** Christian 88%, other 12%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** Lats**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 70 years**People per doctor:** 333**Televisions:** 492 per 1,000 people**LITHUANIA****Capital city:** Vilnius**Area:** 25,174 sq miles (65,200 sq km)**Population:** 3,400,000**Official language:** Lithuanian**Major religions:** Christian 88%, other 12%**Government:** Multiparty democracy**Currency:** Litas**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 73 years**People per doctor:** 250**Televisions:** 459 per 1,000 people

ESTONIA

A LAND OF FORESTS, low hills, and lakes, Estonia is the smallest of the Baltic States. Once a farming nation, the Soviets transformed Estonia into an urban, industrialized region. Today its industries include logging, shipbuilding, and food processing. Since becoming independent from the former USSR in 1991, tensions have sprung up between native Estonians and the third of the population that is Russian.

LATVIA

SANDWICHED BETWEEN the other Baltic States, Latvia's central position, with easy access to the coast and three major ports, has done much to help trade. The cool, damp climate is well suited to dairy farming and meat production. Since becoming independent from the USSR in 1991, Latvia has concentrated on developing its farming, fishing, and logging industries, which had been overshadowed by large-scale factory production under the Soviets.

LITHUANIA

IN MANY WAYS, LITHUANIA stands apart from the other Baltic States. First, most of its people are native Lithuanians, whereas Estonia and Latvia have large Russian populations. Second, life here tends to be concentrated in the interior of the country, away from the coast. The third major difference lies in the fertile soil, which makes farming vital to the economy.

FOLK TRADITIONS

The songs, dances, music, and crafts of their folk history have great value for the people of the Baltic States. Keeping folk traditions alive became especially important as a way of maintaining a sense of identity under Soviet rule. Now, each country has annual folk festivals and parades.

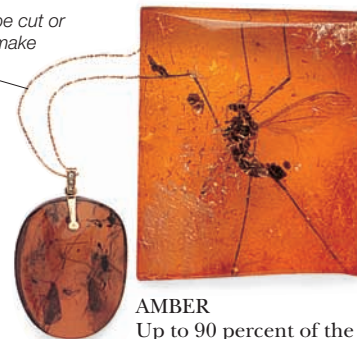
**TALLINN**

Roughly one-third of the people of Estonia live in or around the capital city of Tallinn. A regular flow of tourists comes to wander around the narrow, medieval streets of the city's old quarter.

**RIGA**

The capital has been an important trading port since the Middle Ages. This is perhaps the most lively capital in the Baltic States and it is a vital cultural center. Latvia has strong historic links with Germany, and this can be seen at every turn in Riga – in the buildings, the fashions, and the many German visitors.

Amber can be cut or polished to make jewelry.



A prehistoric fly has been caught in a tree's sticky resin, which then hardened into amber over time.

AMBER

Up to 90 percent of the world's amber comes from the shores of Lithuania, where it is found in sands dating back 50 million years. Amber is a fossilized tree resin, found in chunks of different shapes and sizes. Some is opaque and brown, but the most sought-after amber is yellow or gold. One small piece may contain the remains of insects or plants, trapped forever in the golden resin.

Find out more

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